



FOLLOWING THE LIGHT OF THE SUN WE LEFT THE OLD WORLD

**CHRISTOPHER COLUMBUS
REACHES AMERICA (1492)**

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Voyages of discovery

BEFORE

1431 Portuguese navigator Gonçalo Velho sails on a voyage of exploration to the Azores.

1488 Bartolomeu Dias rounds the Cape of Good Hope, discovering the passage around southern Africa.

1492 King Ferdinand and Queen Isabella of Spain agree to sponsor Columbus's voyage.

AFTER

1498 Vasco da Gama's fleet arrives in Calicut, India.

c. 1499 Italian explorer Amerigo Vespucci discovers the mouth of the Amazon.

1522 Ferdinand Magellan's Spanish expedition to the East Indies, from 1519 to 1522 results in the first circumnavigation of the Earth.

Christopher Columbus (c. 1451–1506), an Italian-born navigator and trader from Genoa, made a journey in 1492 that initiated a lasting contact between America and Europe, and changed the world.

When he set out, Columbus was expecting to reach Asia, since no Europeans at the time knew that an entire continent

blocked this route. When he reached an island in the Bahamas after sailing for over two months, he believed that he had arrived at the outer reaches of Indonesia. From there, Columbus continued to explore the Caribbean, visiting Cuba, Hispaniola, and several of the smaller islands. He met with a mostly peaceful response from the native people, whom he observed might make good servants or enslaved people. He also noticed their gold jewelry, and took a sample of local gold, as well as some native prisoners, back to Europe.

Columbus was to return to the Caribbean on three later voyages, bringing in his wake countless European visitors and settlers.

Motivation to explore

The rulers and merchants of Western Europe wanted to explore the Atlantic for primarily economic reasons. Spices that would not grow in Europe's climate, such as cinnamon, cloves, ginger, nutmeg, and pepper, were prized not only for their taste but also because they could help preserve foods. There was also an enthusiastic market for luxury goods such as silk and precious stones, commodities that came primarily from the islands of the Indonesian group, such as the Moluccas, which were known in Europe as the Spice Islands.

Bringing such commodities across Asia by land was difficult and dangerous because of local wars and instabilities along the route; it was also costly, since during their journey goods would pass through many different merchants' hands. There were certainly excellent economic